

Chapter Three

The north wind arrived before its clouds. It moved over the water in a cold flat line, flattening the swells and driving the gulls inland, and the whole town knew what it meant.

They battened the boats and the shutters and the windows while the light of the tower turned against the darkening sky, and no one spoke of the sea, as if naming it would make it louder.

Chapter Four

When the lamp came round to the west, Elias saw a green hull riding low beyond the harbor mouth, and he knew the season had changed for good. He wrote the sighting in the ledger with a steady hand, and then he went down the stairs to wake the one person in the town who would know what to do with it.

Chapter Five

The fishing fleet put out before dawn in a long ragged line, each boat following the one ahead until the harbor was only a pale notch behind them. The season that followed would be remembered for its northern winds and for the green hull that rode them home.

Chapter Six

By midsummer the tower had a new coat of white paint and a new keeper's book with the old one's first line copied out at the top of the first page. Some things are worth keeping when they are handed over.

Chapter Seven

Mira kept her own log at the foot of the tower, of comings and goings and of the weather as it arrived and passed. In time the book at the top of the stairs and the book at the bottom of the stairs began to tell one story together.